UNIT 1: BEGINNING YOUR JOURNEY, CAREER READINESS ORIENTATION

TOPIC 1: ORIENTATION AND PROFESSIONALISM

Topic OBJECTIVES: The learner will:

- Understand the program expectations and policies
- Get to know the other program participants
- Better understand professionalism

Topic OUTCOMES: The learner will:

- Help to create the program Ground Rules
- Identify his/her expectations
- Make commitments for the next two weeks
- Participate in role plays to practice professionalism

Topic ACTIVITIES:

I. Welcome and Introductions

Opening Question:

- What is your greatest strength?
- What does it mean to be professional?
- What is one thing you hope to learn today (or in this program)?
- What is the ideal job (or career) for you?
- What are three words you would use to describe yourself?

Opening Quote:

- "Our greatest glory is not in never falling but in rising every time we fall."
  ~ *Confucius* (Eastern thinker and social philosopher)
- "If your actions inspire others to dream more, learn more, do more and become more, you are a leader."
  ~ *John Quincy Adams* (US president)
- "Our lives improve only when we take chances — and the first and most difficult risk we can take is to be honest with ourselves."
  ~ *Walter Anderson* (author)
- "From success to failure is one step, from failure to success is a long road."
  ~ *Yiddish Proverb*
- "Opportunity may knock only once, but temptation leans on the doorbell."
  ~ *Anonymous*

II. Expectations for Training

- It is important to clearly communicate expectations to program participants and to give them an opportunity to think about and communicate their expectations.
- Creating a program contract is a great way to outline program expectations, policies and consequences.

  Suggested Program Expectations:
  - Coming Every Day on Time
  - Being Open to Learning
  - Honest Participation and Reflection
  - Respect
  - Professionalism (longer discussion of what that means will take place later in the session)
  - Willingness to Make Mistakes
- Participants should then be given some time to think about, write down, and share their expectations with the group. While participants are sharing their expectations, facilitators should:
  - Take notes
  - After listening to all of the expectations, be honest and direct if the expectation will not be met in the program (for example — guarantee of a private sector job)
  - Post all expectations and try to make sure to meet expectations
    - *Expectations will probably not be the same for all participants — they might want to get different things out of the training — that is okay*

III. Ground Rules

- These can be based on expectations, but must be agreed upon by everyone.
- Ask for suggestions and write them on flipchart paper — usually the young people will say everything that is important, but if they miss something that you think is important, ask them if you can add it to the list.
- Before you finalize the ground rules, ask if everyone can agree to the entire list. If there are some things on the list that some people cannot agree to, make sure you have a conversation and create a list to which everyone can agree before moving on.
- Have everyone initial or sign the ground rules to signify agreement.

IV. Get-to-Know-Each-Other Activities

1. Two Truths and a Lie

Supplies: Paper and pen or pencil for each participant

Directions:

- Ask everyone to write three things about herself/himself on a piece of paper — two things should be true, and one should be false (but not too crazy — something that could be true for someone in the room).
- Collect all of the papers, shuffle them and read them one at a time.
- After you read the three statements, the group has to guess: who wrote them and which statement is false.
- At the end of the exercise, ask what people learned about each other — you could have candy or some other small reward for paying attention and participating to reinforce focus, participation and remembering — key work skills.

2. Blanket Name Game

Supplies: Blanket, tarp or dark sheet that you cannot see through

Directions:

- Create two teams.
- Have the two teams go to opposite sides of the room and sit down.
- Explain the game:
  - The goal is to get everyone on your team.
  - Each team will choose one person to be 'it' for the round.
  - The 'it' people have to kneel close to the blanket.
  - The facilitator(s) will drop the blanket when the two 'it' people are ready.
  - As soon as the blanket drops, the 'it' people have to try to say each other's name.
  - Whoever says the other person's correct name first takes that person back to their team.
  - Play continues until everyone ends up on one side or people are tired of playing.
- At the end of the game, try to see if anyone can remember everyone's name — candy or other small reward might encourage participation.

3. Group Up

Supplies: Questions

Directions:

- Let participants know you are going to ask questions and you want them to 'group up' with other people in the room who would answer the question in the same way as you.
- Depending on the question, give participants a chance to discuss their answers in the small group or with the large group.
- Sample Questions:
  - What is your favorite season?
  - What is your favorite kind of food?
  - If you could travel to another country, where would you go?
  - What is your favorite sport?
  - Would you rather watch TV, play video games or listen to music?
  - What is your favorite school subject?
  - What do you like better,, ice cream or cake?
  - If you could only eat one thing for lunch for the rest of your life, would you choose pizza, chicken, burgers, or subs?
  - What do you think is the best thing about your community?

4. Candy

Supplies: Candy

Directions:

- Put a bunch of wrapped candies in a bowl. (Starbursts, Hershey's Kisses, and Mini Candy Bars work well, but you can use anything).
- Pass the candy around and ask participants to take a handful. Instruct them not to eat any of the candy yet.
- For each piece of candy the person takes, he or she has to share something about himself/herself.

5. Similarities and Differences

Supplies: Handout: **"Similarities and Differences,"** pens/pencils

Directions:

- Have participants walk around, meeting each other — for each person they 'meet', they need to find something they have in common (both like pizza) and one thing that is different (plays basketball/plays football) and fill out all three columns on their sheet.
- At the end, ask people to share some of the things they discovered. Did anything surprise them? How hard was it to find things they had in common with the other participants?

6. Warp Speed

Supplies: Four balls (tennis balls, stress balls), stopwatch

Directions:

- Have everyone get in a circle.
- Give one ball to one person.
- Tell them to choose someone to throw the ball to — say that person's name to make sure they are ready and throw the ball. That person chooses someone else to throw the ball to, says that person's name and throws the ball. This continues until all of the participants have gotten the ball once and it is thrown back to the first person.
- After the pattern has been established and the group is ready for the next challenge — add the other balls.
- When they successfully get all four balls around to everyone in the correct order, tell them you are now going to time them.
- After you time them once, let them know that they have four more tries to decrease the time it takes to get all four balls back to the first person.
  - *At this point, they can move any way they want to be more efficient.*
- Possible Discussion Questions:
  - What was your first strategy to go faster? Did it work?
  - How did you decide what to do?
  - Did someone take the lead? If yes, who? Was everyone else okay with that?
  - How did the group communicate?
  - Did anyone have an idea that they did not get a chance to share? Did you try to share your idea? If not, why not? If so, why do you think people did not listen?
  - Did anyone get frustrated? If so, how did you handle your frustration?
  - What other strategies did you try? Which strategy worked best?
  - Did people change positions in the circle?
  - Did the group pass all of the balls at once?
  - Looking back, is there another strategy that might have worked better?
  - How could the lessons from this activity be applied to a work situation?

V. Professionalism

- One of the expectations is 'Be Professional' — but what does that mean? What do 'professional' people do?
- Use the article Are You a Professional? http://www.tipsforsuccess.org/professionalism.htm

  Discussion:
  - Do you agree with this article? Why or why not?
  - Which three statements describe you? Which three do you want to focus on? Which three are most important to you?
- Practice Professionalism through role-plays. Have the young people do the role-plays twice, handling the situation unprofessionally and then professionally.

Role Play Ideas:

1. You are waiting for the bus to go to an interview, but it is already 10 minutes late and you still don't see it. If it does not get here in the next five minutes, you will be late for your interview.
2. One of your supervisors at Stop & Shop is always giving you the worst jobs — cleaning up spills, getting the carts when it is raining — and you are tired of it. You decide to talk to your supervisor about it.
3. You have been doing a great job at work. You just earned a $.50/hour raise and you also have some new responsibilities, but you are not sure how to do one of the new tasks. You don't want to lose your raise.
4. You are working at the ticket counter of a movie theater. Someone comes over to you to complain about the dirty bathroom.
5. Your new boss asks for your e-mail address so she can send you the weekly employee announcements; the only e-mail address you have is: uknowuwantme@gmail.com
6. Your drawer is $20 short at the end of your shift and you have no idea why.
7. Three of your friends ask you to buy them some sneakers with your employee discount at your new job; they all wear different size shoes.
8. You are working at Dunkin' Donuts when one of your customers comes back and complains that you messed up their order. They demand their money back.
9. Two weeks ago you told your supervisor that you were going to be away this upcoming weekend. You just checked this week's schedule and you are scheduled for Friday afternoon and Sunday morning.
10. You had a great interview for a summer job that you really want. You thought it went really well, especially because they called your references who told you they spoke very highly of you. However, it has been a week and you have not heard back about the job. You decide to call to check in about your application. You speak to the person who interviewed you and he tells you that they hired someone else for the position. You are disappointed because you really thought you were going to get the job. You ask him if he could tell you why. He tells you that he is not supposed to, but since he liked you when you came in, he will tell you. He explains that his supervisor called you to let you know that you had the job, but when she heard your cell phone message, she changed her mind.

- Discuss the situations after the role-plays to see if there are other 'professional' ways to deal with the various situations.

VI. Create Three Commitments for the Next Two Weeks

Possible Commitments:

- I commit to being here on time every day
- I commit to learning at least one new thing in each training
- I commit to participating and contributing every day
- I commit to being open to listening to other people
- I commit to completing the training
- I commit to having fun
- I commit to paying attention to my 'triggers' — the things that upset me

VII. Evaluate the Day (Plus/Delta)

- Ask participants for feedback on the training session.
  - Plus = what went well
  - Delta = what would have made it better

Real-World Application: *Pay attention to how 'professional' people are when you come in contact with them while they are at work — for example: bus driver, store clerk, teacher, security guard, etc. Who do you think will get promoted? Get a raise? Reach their goals? Why?*

Are You a Professional?

How you look, talk, write, act and work determines whether you are a professional or an amateur. Society does not emphasize the importance of professionalism, so people tend to believe that amateur work is normal. Many businesses accept less-than-good results.

Schools graduate students who cannot read. You can miss 15% of the driving-test answers and still get a driver's license. "Just getting by" is an attitude many people accept. But it is the attitude of amateurs.

- A professional learns every aspect of the job. An amateur skips the learning process whenever possible.
- A professional carefully discovers what is needed and wanted. An amateur assumes what others need and want.
- A professional looks, speaks and dresses like a professional. An amateur is sloppy in appearance and speech.
- A professional keeps his or her work area clean and orderly. An amateur has a messy, confused or dirty work area.
- A professional is focused and clear-headed. An amateur is confused and distracted.
- A professional does not let mistakes slide by. An amateur ignores or hides mistakes.
- A professional jumps into difficult assignments. An amateur tries to get out of difficult work.
- A professional completes projects as soon as possible. An amateur is surrounded by unfinished work piled on top of unfinished work.
- A professional remains level-headed and optimistic. An amateur gets upset and assumes the worst.
- A professional handles money and accounts very carefully. An amateur is sloppy with money or accounts.
- A professional faces up to other people's upsets and problems. An amateur avoids others' problems.
- A professional uses higher emotional tones: enthusiasm, cheerfulness, interest, contentment. An amateur uses lower emotional tones: anger, hostility, resentment, fear, victim.
- A professional persists until the objective is achieved. An amateur gives up at the first opportunity.
- A professional produces more than expected. An amateur produces just enough to get by.
- A professional produces a high-quality product or service. An amateur produces a medium-to-low quality product or service.
- A professional earns high pay. An amateur earns low pay and feels it's unfair.
- A professional has a promising future. An amateur has an uncertain future.
- The first step to making yourself a professional is to decide you ARE a professional...
  Are you a professional?

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Similarities and Differences

NAME	SIMILAR	DIFFERENT